

Tristan Dnd Better and Cool and stuff

House Ashcroft occupied an unusual place among Waterdeep's nobility.

Nobody considered them poor. Their estate overlooked one of the quieter streets, its marble walls adorned with generations of enchanted paintings and carefully maintained gardens. Servants attended dinners. Tutors instructed children in etiquette and history. Visitors were served expensive wines and entertained with discussions on politics, philosophy, foreign affairs, and magical theory.

Yet, despite the refinement, the House of Ashcroft lacked the influence enjoyed by Waterdeep's greatest noble families.

They possessed respect rather than power. Prestige rather than authority.

For generations the Ashcrofts had made their fortunes funding magical research instead of military campaigns. They produced scholars instead of generals, arcanists instead of politicians. While other noble houses competed for influence in court the Ashcrofts quietly sponsored libraries, arcane colleges, and magical expeditions. Their family motto reflected this philosophy:

"Knowledge Outlives Crowns"

Every Ashcroft child learned those words before they could properly write their own name. None embraced them more enthusiastically than Tristan.

Magic fascinated him long before he understood it. As a child he'd wander the family library while other children fenced in the courtyard or attended lavish social gatherings. Shelves stretched from polished floors to vaulted ceilings, packed with spellbooks collected across centuries.

Where most children would have seen dusty old tomes Tristan saw treasure.

He spent countless afternoons hiding behind oversized reading desks, struggling through books that always exceeded his age. When servants searched the manor for him, they almost always found him asleep beside a stack of spellbooks, ink staining his sleeves and parchments scattered across the floor.

His parents initially dismissed it as childish curiosity but the tutors realised otherwise. By 10 he could identify magical sigils that others his age were confused on. By 12 he was correcting his instructors. By 14 he asked questions even seasoned mages struggled to find an answer for.

Praise came easily. Too easily. Every successful spell earned admiration.

Every examination ended with another instructor marveling at his potential.

Every family gathering became another opportunity for relatives to remark that Tristan will become the greatest wizard the family ever produced.

He wasn't merely good, in his own opinion, he is destined for greatness.

By eighteen, admission into one of Waterdeep's most respected magical guilds seemed inevitable.

The acceptance letter arrived during breakfast. When read aloud to the family he pretended to care while internally being overcome with emotion as his mother cried and his father opened a bottle of wine reserved for special occasions.

Tristan accepted their congratulations with his practiced humility while privately thinking the guild should feel honored to have accepted him.

The guild's headquarters exceeded even his expectations.

Ancient towers rose above Waterdeep's skyline, their highest spires disappearing into the drifting clouds of light. Enchanted staircases rearranged themselves between lectures. Libraries stretched for floors beneath the city, guarded by wards older than some kingdoms. Wizards from all over walked these halls debating magical theory with the casual confidence as people discussing weather.

For the first time in his life, Tristan found himself surrounded by people as intelligent as he was. He hated it. Not because they outshone him, few ever could, but because they refused to acknowledge that he outshone them.

Students who had once been celebrated prodigies in their own cities challenged his theories without hesitation. Professors dismissed his arguments with polite smiles before reducing them to dust with centuries of experience. Every lecture introduced another mage whose accomplishments dwarfed anything Tristan had done.

Rather than humbling him, it only sharpened his competitive streak.

He studied longer than every one else. Practiced harder. Read deeper into subjects his instructors insisted were too advanced.

Within a few years he'd established himself as the undeniably gifted spellcaster. Even those who disliked him admired his talent.

Unfortunately, almost everyone disliked him.

Although naturally quiet, Tristan possessed an uncanny ability to dominate any conversation he'd join. A casual discussion about cantrips somehow became an opportunity to remind others of his nobility or to boast that his theories were decades ahead of everyone else's.

His instructors often remarked that Tristan possessed all the qualities required to become a legendary wizard. They simply wished he possessed a few qualities required to be a tolerable colleague.

Ironically, his greatest flaw wasn't his arrogance. It was his impatience.

Tristan believed the guild's senior mages had become prisoners to tradition. Every dangerous artifact remained locked away. Every controversial theory was buried beneath layers of bureaucracy. Every ambitious experiment required endless permissions, reviews, committees, and approval.

To Tristan, caution looked remarkably similar to cowardice.

If magical progress had always relied upon permission, he reasoned, no great discovery would ever be made.

So he just stopped asking.

Late at night, after the halls had emptied and the libraries fell silent, Tristan began to slip into sections of the guild reserved for the seniors.

The first time was simple curiosity. The second time was for research. By the tenth, it became routine.

He would read forbidden grimoires, copy unfinished theories, and examined magical relics sealed away generations earlier. Most of what he found merely confirmed what he'd always suspected; the guild knew far more than what it was willing to teach.

Then he found a magical focus resting beneath layers of containment wards alongside a report written nearly two centuries earlier. The conclusion was brief:

"Unstable"

"Activation attempts permanently suspended"

Tristan read every page twice.

The researchers claimed the focus amplified magical energy beyond predictable limits before becoming horrifyingly unstable.

He noticed something they had overlooked, at least, he believed he had.

For nearly a month he filled notebooks with calculations, corrections, and revised activation sequences. Each equation strengthened his conviction that the original researchers had simply misunderstood their own work.

They hadn't failed because the artifact was impossible to control. They failed because they just weren't clever enough.

The experiment itself lasted less than a minute. The explosion will be remembered for decades.

A pulse of wild arcane energy tore through the laboratory, shattering containment circles, reducing centuries of priceless research to drifting ash. Wards throughout the guild failed simultaneously. Windows burst outward across three towers. Every mage in the building felt the surge.

By sheer luck no one died though several came close.

The investigation required no time. There had been records. And there was one spectacularly overconfident apprentice standing at the center of it all.

The verdict was unanimous.

Tristan Ashcroft was expelled from the guild for gross negligence, unauthorized access to restricted archives, reckless endangerment, and conduct unbecoming of a guild member.

Officially, that was the end of the matter.

Unofficially, Tristan maintained they had expelled him for a much simpler reason.

They couldn't stand the thought of someone younger and smarter proving them wrong.

It was a version of events he repeated so often that, eventually, even he stopped questioning whether it was true.

The House of Ashcroft handled the scandal with practiced discretion. No public denunciations. No dramatic disowning. Just polite social distancing.

Financial support quietly disappeared. Invitations to important social gatherings became increasingly rare. His parents informed him, in such diplomatic language it almost sounded encouraging, that the onus of repairing the family name fell onto him.

Many expected him to leave Waterdeep.

He refused.

Leaving would be surrender. Waterdeep was where he "failed." Therefore it must also be where his triumph must occur as well.

Every influential guild, every wealthy patron, every renowned adventurer, every opportunity worth seizing existed within the city's walls.

History would remember Tristan vi Ashcroft.